

Three Atoms Ahead.. I Am Always Three Atoms Ahead

Your humble reporter, Sarah Asraf, reporting from the UNCND Committee, with an Op-Ed delving into why international drug scheduling still can't outrun a local chemist



Source: INTERNATIONAL DRUG LAWS by Paresh Nath

In December of 1985, a 175-pound black bear died in Georgia's Chattahoochee National Forest after consuming a large quantity of cocaine.¹ The bear, nicknamed “Pablo Escobear” or “Cocaine Bear”, had ingested duffel bags dropped by a drug trafficker and smuggler, Andrew Thornton II, a former narcotics officer who died jumping out of a plane into the same forest just weeks prior. The bear ate what is described as an amount of cocaine so great no mammal could live through it, and it died within what is believed to be a matter of hours.²

It is a grotesque and almost comical addendum to the war on drugs. But it is also, in an unintended way, a parable. An animal came across a substance that it didn't know anything about, ingested it, and paid the price of that lack of knowledge with its life. Forty years later, human beings have not

¹ Wikipedia contributors. (n.d.). *Cocaine Bear (bear)*. In Wikipedia. Retrieved September 12, 2026, from [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cocaine_Bear_\(bear\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cocaine_Bear_(bear))

² Today I Found Out. (n.d.). *The curious case of Pablo EskoBear—the “Cocaine Bear”*. <https://www.todayifoundout.com/index.php/2017/08/amazing-tale-kentucky-folk-hero-pablo-eskobear-cocaine-bear/>

fared much better. We have simply substituted the duffel bag with a dark net market and a 3D pill press, and the bear with tens of thousands of individuals who pay for that with their lives.

Supply Moves Faster than the State

Let us look at two facts from different ends of the drug market chain. First, in India, Kerala's state government has initiated a campaign called “*Operation Toofan*”, within the first 100 days of which it has registered over 10,000 cases and arrested more than 10,800 people while confiscating tens of thousands of grams of MDMA and over one ton of cannabis.³ This is an extensive and resourceful enforcement effort but, at its core, is reactive since it pursues the drug that has made it to the streets.

On the other hand, the Reuters investigation conducted in 2025 revealed that a group of journalists can purchase all necessary chemicals needed to produce \$3 million worth of fentanyl for less than \$3,600. These chemicals were obtained legally, and the majority of them came from China because of the flaws in customs regulations and exemptions for low-value shipments.⁴ The fact that supply chain innovations precede updates in the control list by months or even years is the true crisis of the “*emerging psychoactive substances*” agenda.

The UNCND and Its Battle Against Time

For its part, the Commission on Narcotic Drugs is far from doing nothing. At its recent 69th session, the UN body agreed to schedule three new psychoactive substances, among which were two new synthetic opioids from the nitazene class, which are even more potent than fentanyl, according to recommendations from the World Health Organisation. The body created a new independent expert panel which will review the entire system of international drug control before its 2029 progress review. However, the same session was characterised by the failure of the Vienna Consensus, with more resolutions being adopted by voting and not through agreement. This

³ The Times of India. (n.d.). *Operation Toofan: Crackdown on drug mafia nearing 100 days*. <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/thiruvananthapuram/operation-toofan-crackdown-on-drug-mafia-nearing-100-days/articleshow/133812716.cms>

⁴ Reuters. (n.d.). *We bought what's needed to make millions of fentanyl pills—for \$3,600*. <https://www.reuters.com/investigates/special-report/usa-fentanyl-supply-chain-shipping/>

indicates that states are drifting apart even on the fundamental questions of harm reduction and human rights despite the rapid pace of the chemistry.⁵

This is what the agenda item is in fact addressing: speed vs. sovereignty and control vs. access. The system of scheduling that was developed for the times when there were only a few dozen known narcotics cannot cope with the thousands of novel psychoactive substances synthesised by the server-based chemistry.

Where the Line Should Be Drawn

The status quo, made substance by substance, by one decision per year in Vienna, cannot move fast enough to respond to a constantly morphing problem. States must support an Early Warning Advisory system that is properly funded and empowered to implement provisional and limited controls as soon as WHO's Expert Committee alerts the system to the presence of new analogues, without waiting for the next CND meeting. Such a provisional schedule would automatically expire, unless formally adopted at the next CND session, thereby preserving scientific thoroughness while maintaining state sovereignty over final decision-making. An accelerated process needs an unambiguous carve-out to protect medicines and scientific research, to be assessed separately and rapidly from the process of control. In this way, the drive for speed does not inadvertently create a drive for blanket prohibition.

The bear in Georgia did not have an early warning system, nor a controlled environment, nor time to figure out the danger. It's now for the world to show it can do better than just one bear, in a wood, with another person's stuff. The CND has the organisation, the scientific know-how, and the global reach. What it needs now is speed, for in the age of artificial drugs, yesterday's solution is bound to be tomorrow's loophole.

⁵ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2026, March). *Three NPS placed under international control at the 69th Session of the Commission on Narcotic Drugs*. <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/frontpage/2026/March/cnd-closing.html>